Appian Academy



Build an Application: Step-by-Step #5

Interfaces, Reports, and Sites

The Appian Step-by-Step series consists of 5 modules that accompany the courses in the Appian Developer learning path. Each module contains a set of exercises that correspond to the topics you learned in the preceding courses.

1 Introduction

2 Construct Your Data Fabric

3 Application Actions

4 Create the User Experience

5 **Interfaces, Reports, and Sites**

Complete exercises in order and keep the app and all objects until you are done with the project.

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This exercise was developed for **Appian 26.6**. If Appian Community Edition is on a later Appian version, functionality might be different. Go to academy.appian.com to download the latest exercise.

Exercise 1: Add and Configure a Read-Only Grid

In this exercise, you will create interfaces with read-only grids that display data based on the record lists for the **W#ER Customer**, **W#ER Equipment**, and **W#ER Rental Request** record types. You will later add these interfaces to a dashboard for Acme Sport employees.

User Stories



As a Support Agent or Support Supervisor, I want to see a landing page of all relevant record types, so that I can easily perform my job duties.

Create a Reusable Interface

Follow the steps below to create an interface that contains a record-backed, read-only grid.

1. In the **Build** view, click **NEW** > **Interface**.
2. In the **Create Interface** dialog, configure the following:
    - **Name**: Enter `W#ER_CustomerRecordGrid`
    - **Description**: Enter `A read-only grid of the W#ER Customer record type.`
    - **Save In**: Save the interface in the **ER Rules & Constants** folder.
    - Click **CREATE**.
3. In the **Palette**, under **Grids and Lists**, drag a **READ-ONLY GRID** onto the canvas.
4. In the **Component Configuration** pane, under **Label Position**, select **Collapsed**.



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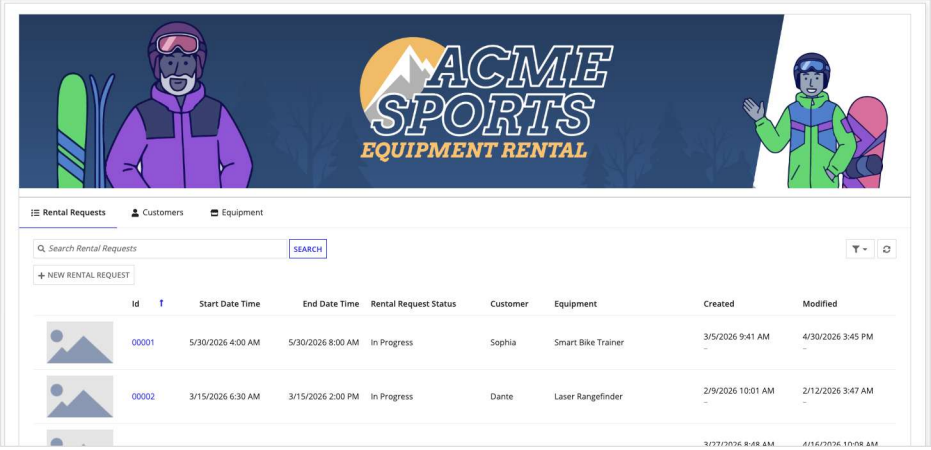
5. In the **Data** tab, under **Data Source**, leave **Record type** selected.
6. In the **Search record types** text box, enter and select **W#ER Customer.**
7. Click **SAVE**.

The read-only grid represents the current record list configuration of the **W#ER Customer** record type. You can further customize the read-only grid to fit the needs of your use case. Later, you will reference this interface as a reusable component.

1. Repeat the steps 1–7 above to create reusable read-only grid interfaces for the **W#ER Equipment** and the **W#ER Rental Request** record types.
    - For the **Equipment** grid, name the interface `W#ER_EquipmentRecordGrid`.
    - For the **Rental Request** grid, name the interface `W#ER_RentalRequestRecordGrid`.

Exercise 2: Create a Landing Page

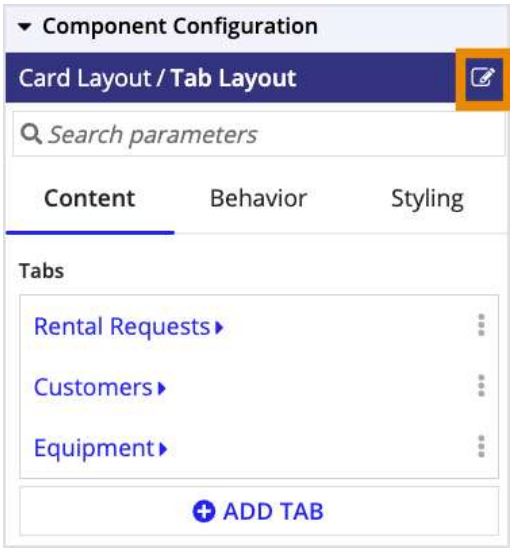
For this exercise, you will complete the configuration of an existing interface **W#ER_SiteLandingPage**. This interface was created for you to support the completion of this exercise.



Follow the steps below to add the reusable read-only grid interfaces to the **W#ER_SiteLandingPage** interface. You will add each interface as the content of a tab in the **Tab Layout** and give the tab a representative icon.

1. In the **Build** view, open the **W#ER_SiteLandingPage** interface.
2. Below the **Billboard** layout, click on the **Tab Layout** component.
3. In the **Component Configuration** pane, to the right of the **Card Layout / Tab Layout** breadcrumbs, click the **Edit as Expression** icon.

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4. In the **Item** expression box, update the **contents** for each **a!tabItem** by calling your previously created read-only grid interfaces.

    - For the first tab, add the **W#ER_RentalRequestRecordGrid** by referencing it with **rule!**. The **a!tabItem()** function should look like the following:

```
a!tabItem(
   label: "Rental Requests",
   icon: "list",
   contents: {
   rule!W#ER_RentalRequestRecordGrid()
   }
 )
```

Expression Tip: This expression creates a new tab in the Tab Layout component. When selected, the tab displays the **W#ER_RentalRequestRecordGrid()** interface.

```
a!tabLayout(
  tabs: {
    a!tabItem(
      label: "Rental Requests",
      icon: "list",
      contents: rule!W000ER_RentalRequestRecordGrid()
    ),
```

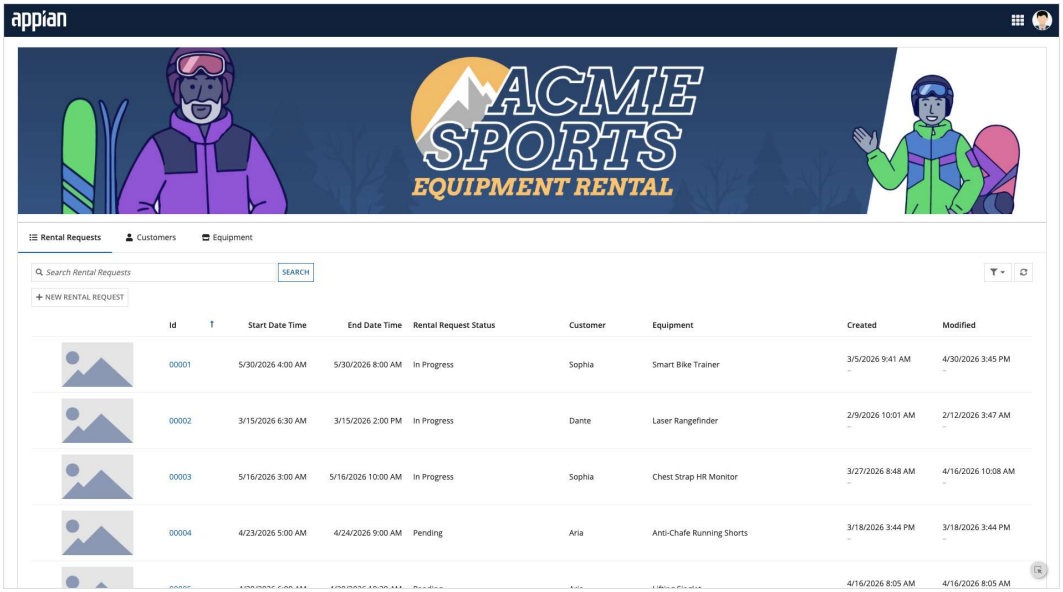
    - Repeat this step to add the interfaces **W#ER_EquipmentRecordGrid** and **W#ER_CustomerRecordGrid**.

5. Once you have updated each tab item, click **OK**, then **SAVE**.

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Exercise 3: Creating and Configuring a Site

In this exercise, you will create and configure a central site object to serve as the primary user interface for the Acme Sport Equipment Rental application. You will add **W#ER_SiteLandingPage** as a site page and adjust branding.



User Stories



As a Support Agent or Support Supervisor, I want a single, centralized dashboard where I can quickly view and switch between the main record types, so I don't have to navigate to separate screens for each.

Create the Site Object

Follow the steps below to create the Acme Sport Equipment Rental site.

1. In the **Build** view, click **NEW** > **Site**.
2. In the Create Site dialog, configure the following:
    - **Name**: Enter `W#ER Acme Sport Equipment Rental`
    - **Display Name**: Enter `Acme Sport Equipment Rental`
    - **Web Address Identifier**: Enter `W#ER-acme-sport-equipment-rental`

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- **Description**: Enter `The Acme Sport Equipment Rental site object.`
- Leave everything else as-is.
- Click **CREATE**.

3. In the **Review Site Security** dialog, click **SAVE**.

Add Pages to the Site

Follow the steps below to add pages to the Acme Sport Equipment Rental site.

1. In the left navigation pane, in the **Pages** section, click **ADD PAGE**.
2. Configure the following:
   - **Title**: Enter `Dashboard`
   - **Type**: Keep **Interface** selected.
   - **Content**: Search for and select **W#ER_SiteLandingPage**
   - Leave everything else as-is.
   - Click **ADD**.
3. Next, scroll down to **Navigation Bar**.
4. Under Layout, select **SIDEBAR**.

   Notice how the Branding Preview pane displays the updated UI. However, since our site only has a single page, it does not make sense to use the SIDEBAR layout.
5. Switch it back to **HEADER BAR**.

   Continue experimenting with the different layouts, colors, and other branding options.
6. Click **SAVE**.

Test the Site

Follow the steps below to test your site and see what it looks like to your business users.

1. Click the link under **Web Address** to open the site in a new tab.
2. Review each tab to verify that the record list displays correctly.

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3. On the **Rental Request** tab, click **+NEW RENTAL REQUEST** and ensure the **Create Rental Request** form opens as expected.

Exercise 4: Reports and Dashboards with Process HQ

In this exercise, you will use Process HQ to create reports for the Acme Sport Equipment Rental application. You will create a report in two different ways: creating a report manually and by chatting with AI Copilot. You will then combine them into a single dashboard for the Acme Sport Equipment Rental site. But first, you will need to add the desired record types as datasets in the Process HQ data catalog.

User Stories



As a Support Supervisor, I want a dashboard where I can view real-time reports, to gain immediate visibility into business performance and make data-driven decisions.

Add Record Types as Datasets in the Data Catalog

Follow the steps below to add your record types as datasets.

1. In the **Build** view, open the **W#ER Rental Request** record type.
2. In the left navigation pane, click on **Workspaces**.
3. In the **Workspaces** page, under **Data Fabric Insights**, select the checkbox for **Show this record type as a dataset in the Data Catalog of Process HQ**
4. Click **SAVE**.
5. Repeat the above steps for the **W#ER Equipment** record type.

Create a Report from a Dataset

Follow the steps to create a report using the dataset of a record type.

1. At the top right of your screen, click the **Navigation Menu** > **Process HQ**.
2. Under **Reports and Dashboards**, click **CREATE REPORT**.
3. In the **My Report** page, under **DATASETS**, select **Equipment**.

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4. In the upper left of the designer, to the right of Rental Requests Report, click the **Edit report name and description**  icon.

   In the Edit Report Properties dialog, configure the following:

   - **Name**: Enter `W#ER Number of Requests by Equipment`
   - **Description**: Enter `A grid showing the number of rental requests by equipment.`
   - **Application**: Enter and select **W#ER Acme Sport Equipment Rental**.

   Note: The Report object will be automatically added to the application. Otherwise, the object will exist in the environment, but not to any specific application. This is an important step when it comes to deployment to ensure the Report object is in the correct application container.

   - Click **UPDATE**.

5. In the left pane, under **FIELDS**, use the dropdown to select the following fields:
   - Name
   - Count of Requests
6. Click **SAVE**.

Create a Report using AI Copilot

Follow the steps below to create a report in Process HQ using AI Copilot.

1. Using the navigation on the left side, click the **Home**  icon.
2. On the right side, in the **AI Copilot** pane, enter the following:

   `I need a line chart that shows the number of rental requests created this year by month.`

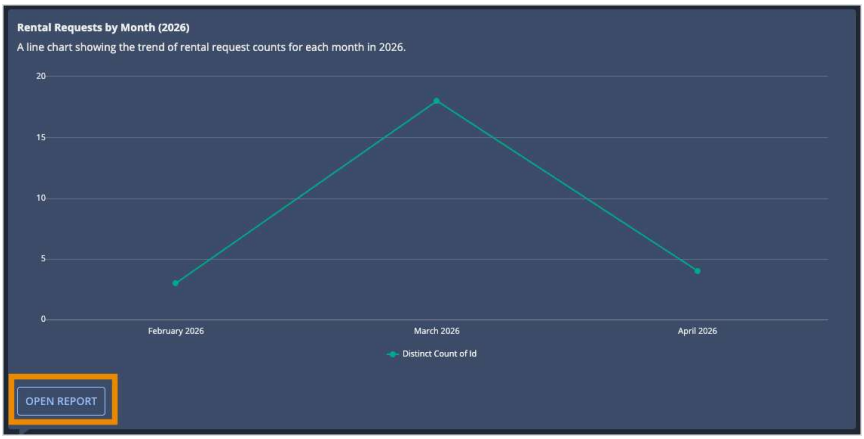
3. Press **ENTER** or click the paper airplane icon.
4. Once the chart has been generated, at the top right of the AI Copilot pane, click the **Expand** icon.

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Tip: This view provides an easier way to visualize and refine the chart with AI Copilot.

5. Click **OPEN REPORT**.



Note: Your report title and description may be different from the example image above. AI is non-deterministic and may produce a slightly different result. For the purpose of the exercise, you do not need to update the title or description.

6. At the top right, to the right of the report name, click on the **Edit report name and description**  icon.
7. Configure the following:
    - **Name**: Enter `W#ER Rental Requests by Month`
    - **Application**: Type and select **W#ER Acme Sport Equipment Rental.**
8. Click **UPDATE**.
9. In the left pane, under **FIELDS**, click **EDIT DISPLAY NAMES**.
10. Change **Id** to **Rental Requests**
11. Click **OK**.
12. On the right hand side, in **Setup**, under **Design**, toggle off **Show Grid**.



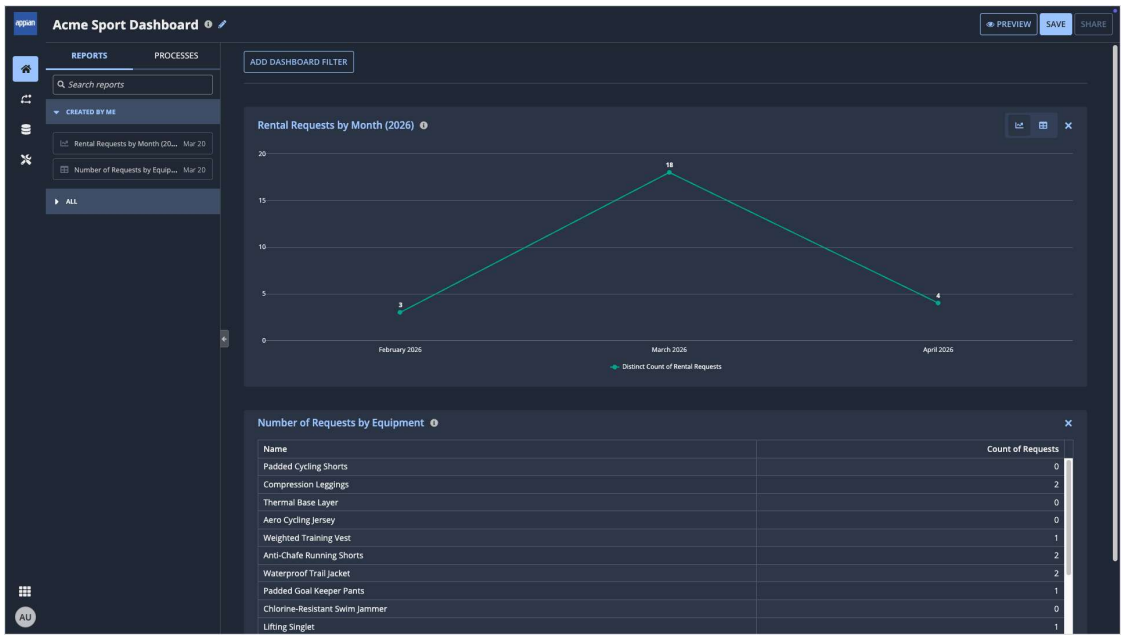
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13. Click **SAVE**.

Create a Process HQ Dashboard

Follow the steps below to create a dashboard in Process HQ.

1. Using the navigation on the left side, click the **Home** icon.
2. On the top right, click **+ CREATE DASHBOARD**.
3. At the top left, to the right of My Dashboard, click the **Edit dashboard name and description**  icon and configure the following:
    - **Name**: Enter `W#ER Acme Sport Dashboard`
    - **Description**: Enter `The report dashboard for the Acme Sport Equipment Rental application.`
    - **Application**: Enter and select **W#ER Acme Sport Equipment Rental**
    - Click **UPDATE**.
4. In the left pane, under **REPORTS**, under **CREATED BY ME**, click and drag the two reports you created earlier onto the canvas. Adjust the layout so the line chart is the first chart.
5. Click **SAVE**.



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Add the PHQ Dashboard to the Acme Sport Site

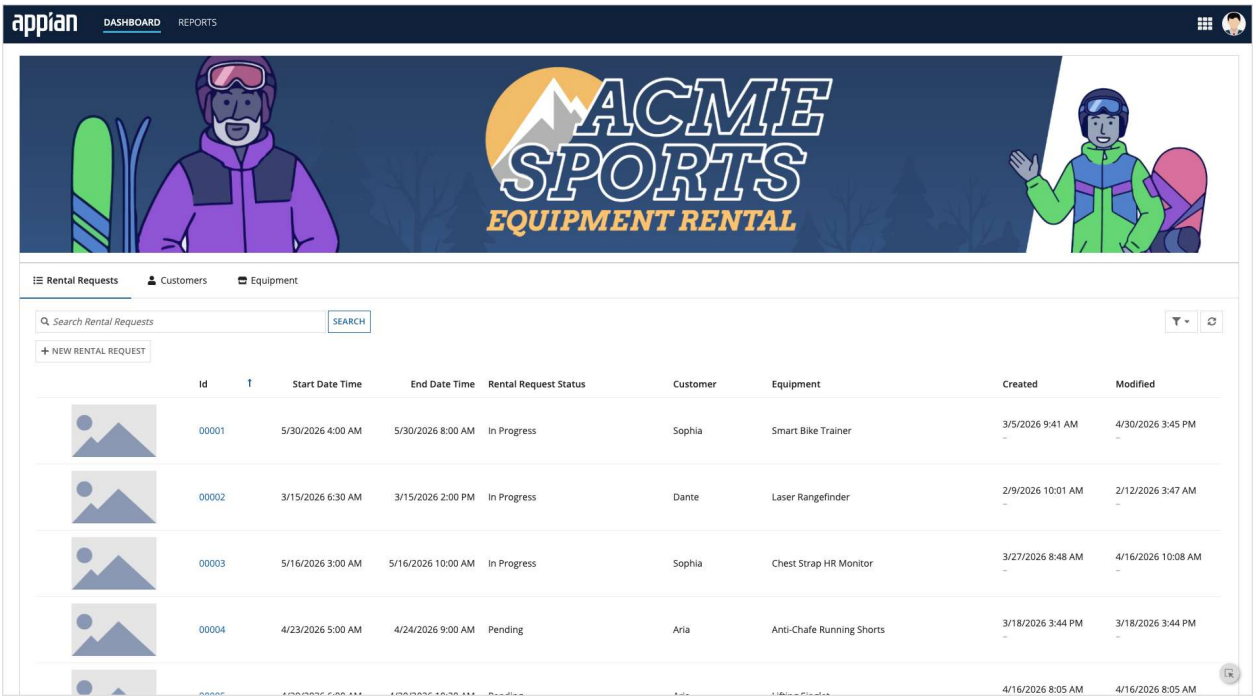
Follow the steps below to add the **W#ER Acme Sport Dashboard** to the **W#ER Acme Sport Equipment Rental** site.

1. In the **Build** view, open **W#ER Acme Sport Equipment Rental** site.
2. Click **ADD PAGE**, and configure the following:
    - **Title**: Enter `Reports`
    - **Type**: Select **Process HQ - Dashboard**.
    - **Content**: Enter and select **W#ER Acme Sport Dashboard**.
    - Leave everything else as-is.
    - Click **ADD.**
3. Click **SAVE**.
4. Click the **Navigation Menu** > **Acme Sport Equipment Rental Site**. Go to the **Reports** page and review the reports you just added.

Test Your Application

Congratulations! You have successfully completed the Appian Developer Step by Steps. Try out your new application by navigating around the Acme Sport Equipment Rental Site, adding rental requests, updating equipment, retiring equipment, etc.

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Next, you can challenge yourself by continuing to improve this application. Find opportunities to streamline the process, providing business the users to self-manage the enter rental process—from request to return. There are many ways to expand the application, explore and see just how far you can go.

Module Recap

In these exercises, you built a front-end user experience by creating interfaces and a site for users. Finally, you used **Process HQ** and **AI Copilot** to transform raw data into a functional reporting dashboard, which you then added to the site navigation.

Why is this important?

- **Modular Reusability**: Creating the record lists as independent interfaces allows you to update the "Customer" or "Equipment" grid in one place and have those changes automatically reflected across every page or dashboard where that component is used.
- **Data-Driven Decision Making**: By enabling record types as datasets and building reports in Process HQ, you provide stakeholders with real-time visibility into business trends, such as rental volumes and customer activity.

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